> Our state has been in existence as an independent nation for thousands of years … It is our bounden duty to defend and safeguard, with our lives, the independence and sovereignty which our martyrs and patriotic heroes wrested back, and to ensure their perpetuity as long as the world exists.[83]

This led to the view that the security of the state relies on maintaining rigorous independence from any external pressures which might seek to interfere with the generals' interpretation of Burmese interests. This was set against a constant fear that external regimes, such as India, China or the former colonial rulers, were actively trying to conspire against Myanmar and seize its assets. Finally, there was, as we have explored earlier, the effort to build a mono-cultural nation based on the idea that the proper and true Burmese citizen was both a Buddhist and of Burman ethnicity.

However, as we have seen, the concept of self-reliance has constantly competed against the need to trade. Trade allowed access to weapons, but it also allowed the generals to monetise their control over Myanmar's assets. This tension came to a head with the discovery of large offshore oil and gas supplies in 2007, leading companies, particularly from China, India, Australia and South Korea, to seek, and eventually secure, exploration licences from the state-owned Myanmar Oil and Gas Enterprise (MOGE).[84] While these are notional joint ventures, the reality is that the foreign partner has to pay all the costs. In addition, India was involved in massive investment in the port facilities at Sittwe and China is funding a pipeline from Sittwe to Kunming in southwest China.[85] This pipeline was part of $8bn of Chinese investments in infrastructure projects in Myanmar in 2009. Politically, the Chinese also agreed to block cross-border movements of ethnic rebel groups, and stated that it wished to see 'stability' (that is, a continuation of the regime) after the November 2010 elections.

In effect, while it is conventional to describe Myanmar as isolated and immune to international pressure, the reality is slightly different. The generals do not care for lectures on how they should behave, and are intensely suspicious that external powers are seeking to intervene in Burma for their own interests. However, they want arms (even if just as prestige projects) and, more importantly, want to realise the wealth they have gathered on the international stage. Increasingly, they also want international investment to improve the country's infrastructure and ease the process of extracting mineral wealth.